

11.10.25

léa

coup de boule, she whispers between
the half-breath of a laugh and a kiss
in the backseat of alejandro's van

the weight of her body pressed
against mine like the raindrops
on the window. she says

she wishes she could freeze time,
and i tell her of the superhero story
i wrote in fourth grade, *beaver freeze*,

my sidekick beaver stopping the hands
of the clock at my command. she suspends
herself in the moments of my arms

like a stopwatch in free fall suddenly
caught in a spider's web.
and as the raindrops freeze on the window

in the reflection of my eyes,
she asks if i feel the drugs. i whisper *not really*
but she murmurs *not those drugs*, and

i understand she doesn't mean the pineapple
tequila we shared at the bar. and as we sink
into the web we both know is fleeting, she

exhales a message from The Dance.
it's easy to forget how easy it is
when you feel it

i knew you would write a poem about me,
she says, as we lie on the carpet of my room
in a pool of mercury. i count the stones
on the bracelet she gave me before
i read her my soul. and then i read it.
and then it's tears, flowing
from the mouth of a river
so deep i cannot touch the bottom.
why is life so cruel ?
she whispers into
the gap between seconds
that no longer exist.

then the stopwatch rolls over,
and it's her turn. she spills *les entrailles*
of her own poem into the corners of my eyes,
and it's love, and confusion, and praise,
and unfairness, and her fingers wiping
at the side of my cheek.
she had already looked at the price
of flying from paris to albuquerque,
she had already cried about it with carla
for three hours last night,
but we both knew that the web of a spider
does not stretch forever.

her lips rustle *maybe*
you will help me love again,
and there are no words. like the finch
in the tree when we met, soundlessly
watching two wandering souls
become lost again. and when
it's morning, it's stillness replaced
by an alarm for the flight
she has to catch.
i was dreaming of the finch.
i'm still thinking of it
as we say goodbye,
and the words cry out from my soul—
why don't birds ever fly away in silence?

léa iii

absence waits patiently
behind the dam until
she's been gone for a while. and then
it crashes, beached waves
reaching to swallow me
up and out. i tell myself
that there's beauty in this pain,
but i can't find it. i search
my thesaurus for words, but
you can't describe with something from the outside.
i think *at least there's human in this pain*, and suddenly
i'm reliving a memory of myself
in paris, watching the *pâtissier*
roll the dough of a croissant into
oblivion. only this time, she's rolling out
a mangled ball of flesh, the entangled swollen
creases of my brain. and then i'm chewing, and
swallowing, and the wad of life becomes
stuck in my throat. now i'm choking, senses
rendered senseless, vision going black. but
out of the corner of my nose, i can just
make out the smell of stones
in a bracelet from a realm without
dimension. somehow, in my soul
i know that the circle of stones is
ouroboric. then there's
impulse, and, with everything
i have left, i stretch out
to grasp the loop, slipping
it back over my wrist.
so that it can feel my heartbeat.

léa iv

acceptance is the only form of healing,
but it makes everything less beautiful
is what she wrote, in the translated

poem she last sent me. *it frees us*
the most, but prevents us from fully
feeling, which reminds me of the secret

that Poetry once whispered in my ear. She
said that a package must always be left slightly
unwrapped, and the thread of a poem should

stop only when the needle gets stuck
in you. perhaps this life is a poem
and léa the needle in my soul. maybe

i shouldn't plug the tear that's leaking
the beats from my heart. and in the tree
above, when the rain drips from the porous

beak of a finch, i should let it hit me.
you ever experience something so
beautiful, you never want to touch it

again. it can never be the same, and
we both know it, but she wants to come
back in april. i sent her the last three,

but i won't send her this poem. because
i didn't tell her, but when the spider's web
snapped, and we fell through it, a piece

of the silk remained stuck around my wrist.
like the thread i'm scared to pull through